

**INFLUENCE OF PARENTAL SEPARATION ON THE ACADEMIC PERFORMANCE
OF SECONDARY SCHOOL STUDENTS IN ENUGU EDUCATION
ZONE OF ENUGU STATE**

AKA, CHINELO PATRICIA

Department of Educational Management, Faculty of Education, Enugu State University of
Science and Technology, Agbani, Enugu State, Nigeria
Corresponding Author: akachinelo@gmail.com

Abstract

The main purpose of this study was to determine the influence of parental separation on the academic performance of students in secondary schools in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State. Three research questions guided the study while four null hypotheses were tested at 0.05 level of significance. Descriptive survey research design was adopted for the study. The population for the study comprised all the 28,310 secondary school students in the 31 public secondary schools in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State. The sample size for this study was 565 public secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State. The sample was made up of 209 male and 356 female secondary school students in the zone. The researcher used proportionate stratified random sampling technique to draw 2% of male and female secondary school students from the 31 public secondary schools in the zone. A self-structured questionnaire was used for data collection. The instrument was validated by three experts. The reliability of the instrument was determined using Cronbach Alpha reliability estimate. The overall reliability coefficient stood at .73, indicating that the instrument was reliable and suitable for the study. Based on the findings of the study it was revealed that to a little extent parental separation influenced the cognitive and psychomotor skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State. More so, it was found that to a great extent parental separation influence the affective skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State. This is supported by the fact that there is significant difference between the mean scores of male and female students on the extent to which parental separation influence the cognitive and psychomotor skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State. But, there was no significant difference between the mean scores of male and female students on the extent to which parental separation influence the affective skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State. The researcher recommended among others that there is need for periodic seminar for parents across all secondary schools in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State to enlighten the parents on the need for good home environment and enhancement of students' academic performance.

Keywords: Academic Performance, Parental Separation, Cognitive Skills, Affective Skills, Psychomotor Skills Secondary School.

Introduction

Parents are the first people every growing child knows and they have vital roles to play in the life of their children. Parents' participation in their children's education has been shown to be an important variable that positively influence their children's education (Epstein, Coates & Salina, 2017). Several schools are therefore appreciating their importance and are encouraging parents to get involved in their children's' education. Epstein, *et.al.* (2017) noted that children learn and grow through three overlapping spheres of influence: viz: family, school and community. These three spheres must form partnerships to best meet the needs of the child. Significant in the family as a sphere of influence to the child are the parents. Parents are one of the most important and influential elements on the lives of their children. According to Saffer (2022), parents are considered as the primary shapers of their children behaviour and performance in school. They have the power, ability to shape, sustain and develop their children who will be interested, creative and tolerant, thorough and positively involved in the learning process and educational activities (Ibem, 2020). On the other hand, parents who are not involved in their children educational growth are considered to be capable of repressing and destroying the motivation and ability of their children through neglect and indifference to their behaviour and academics. It is worthy to note that, parents have been identified to have a critical role in the task of inculcating positive academic behaviour in students. Ncheta (2023), posited that the manner by

which parents raise their children may depend on the parent's level of expectations, performance, domains, and attentiveness to rule as well as the style of discipline that the parents utilize to enforce their expectations. Maccobay and Martin (2018), asserted that, parents may also assist children in learning at home for example in doing homework as well as decision making and collaborating with the school in such areas as provision of resources. When parents continuously support and encourage their children, they learn better, develop high self-esteem, become more self- disciplined, and show higher aspiration and motivation towards improving their academic performance (Epstein, *et al*, 2017). However, there is an indication that these roles played by parents on the academic performance of their children may be challenged when the parents are separated.

Parental separation refers to a situation where a child experiences the absence of one or both parents due to a breakdown in their relationship, usually resulting from divorce or separation, meaning the parents are no longer living together in the same household, impacting the child's family dynamic and potentially causing significant emotional and psychological effects. According to Akabi (2020) parental separation refers to a situation where a child's parents live apart from each other, meaning they are no longer residing in the same household, which can significantly impact the child's life due to the disruption of their family structure and routine, often arising from divorce or legal separation; this can result in various emotional, social, and developmental

challenges for the child depending on the circumstances of the separation and the child's age. Gruber (2024) posited that parental separation is associated with deteriorating material and subjective wellbeing in the short term, resulting in average lower wellbeing later in life and occurs in different forms such as; separation due to death of a parent; marital divorce; job relocation as well as separation due to polygamy effects. Yet with this observable high rate of parental separation, little or nothing has been done to control the seeming influence of parental separation on the academic performance of secondary school students particularly within Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State.

Many researchers have shown that poor academic performance are prevalent among students who are from unstable or separated family, with less adequate parental training on their moral and social attitudes. William (2022) stated that with the increasing number of parental separation, students' academic performance is assumed to be at risk as reports from different researches reveals volumes on the cases of parental separation. For instance, study by Piata (2022) revealed a negative correlation between parental separation and student's academic performance, with children from separated families often experiencing decreased grades, lower engagement in school, and increased behavioural problems, potentially due to the emotional stress and instability associated with the family disruption; this impact can vary depending on the child's age at the time of separation and the level of conflict within the family.

Available statistics as revealed by Devioce.com (2023) indicated that, parental separation rates in Nigeria are at 50% for first marriages, and subsequent marriages are 2.5 times more likely to end in separation. Divorce.com claimed that Nigeria's divorce rate reached 2.9 per cent in 2023 based on available data on marriage and divorce, which translates to 1.8 per cent divorces per 1,000 people in the same year. Consequently, Nigeria was ranked eleventh among the countries with the highest parental separation rate because its women are financially independent and can sustain themselves without husbands. Unfortunately, the United States website (2023) which offers resources and support for navigating separation and divorce, included Nigeria on its list of countries with high parental separation rates. According to data published on their website in July, 2023, Nigeria ranked eleventh out of twenty-six countries with the highest divorce and parental separation rate. The results were meticulously obtained after sampling respondents from these countries and compiling statistics from 16 primary sources, ensuring a comprehensive and reliable research process. The report also revealed a significant trend. Women in sub-Saharan Africa, especially Nigeria, are taking the initiative in divorce or separation more often than men. The alarming reports of parental separation underscore the seriousness of the problem of separation no matter the factors that led to it, such as adultery, incompatibility, poor communication, financial problem, abusive behaviour, lack of commitment to it, alcohol and drug abuse and mental illness and these

call for a serious concern as students' academic performance is assumed to be affected.

Students' academic performance could be defined as the learning outcomes of the child in school. This includes the knowledge, skills and ideas, acquired and obtained through their course of study within and outside the classroom situation (Epunam, 2019). Academic performance relates to academic subjects a child studies in school and the skills the child is expected to master in each (Kathryn, 2020). Academic performance encompasses students' ability and performance; it is multidimensional; it is intricately related to human growth and cognitive, emotional and social physical development; it reflects the whole child; it is not related to a single instance, but occurs across time and levels, through a student's life in public school and into post-secondary years and working life (Steinberger, 2015). Pandney (2018), defined academic performance as the achievement of the pupils in the subjects they study at school. Ugwu (2019), averred that, academic performance refers to how well a student is accomplishing his tasks and studies with reference to his cognitive, affective, and psychomotor skills.

Cognitive skills refer to how an individual processes information, recognizes patterns and analyzes problems. Rex (2020), posited that, the cognitive domain focuses on six intellectual skills which include; knowledge, comprehension, application, analysis, synthesis and evaluation. Cognitive skills are a collection of natural skills that include such things as listening, perception and attention to detail (Ekanem, 2016).

Ugwu (2019), noted that cognitive skills deal with the intellectual side of learning. It refers to knowledge attainment and mental/intellectual processes. They include skills such as reasoning, memory and concentration. Onovo (2022), asserted that the stronger the cognitive skills are established in an individual, the easier it is for the individual to learn. On the contrary, Udoka (2016) posited that negative experiences within a child's environment such domestic violence has significant impact on the cognitive skills of such child. Being that parental separation is on the increase among couples, there is therefore need to ascertain the extent to which parental separation influences the cognitive skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State, as the gap created by this is long overdue. Next to cognitive skills is the affective skill.

Affective skills of learning represent skills that foster appropriate emotional responses. It characterizes the emotional arena reflected by learners' beliefs, values and interest. The affective domain includes the manner in which we deal with things emotionally, such as feelings, values, appreciation, enthusiasms, motivations and attitudes (Ugwu, 2019). Ubaka (2018), noted that like the cognitive skills, the areas of emotional response in the affective domain are; receiving, responding, valuing, organizing and characterizing. Being that the affective domain has to do with emotions and feelings, Lehrer (2018) noted that parental separation has serious negative impact on the human emotion particularly the children. Lehrer, added that children (students) are often the worst hit by the

domestic violence as they usually end up with only one of the parents. This deprives the child or children of important inputs such as quality of care, quality of time, money, family and community resources, to mention but a few. These tend to have both short and long-term negative consequences (Chae, 2020). Okoroafor (2017), stated that parental separation not only affects the behavioural adjustment and potential of students but lead to drop-out from school as a result of difficult emotional experiences and trauma. These calls for a serious concern, however, the extent to which parental separation influence the affective skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State, is a gap of serious concern. Close to affective skills is the psychomotor skill.

Psychomotor skills reflect learning behaviour achieved through neuromuscular motor activities. It focuses on physical skills. Udoka (2016), posited that psychomotor skills help people perform physical tasks in daily life and at work. The areas of the psychomotor domain include; perception, set, guided responses, mechanism, complex overt response, adaptation and origination. Ugwu (2019), stated that the psychomotor domain includes physical movement, coordination, use of the motor-skills areas. Ugwu added that the development of these skills requires practice and it is measured in terms of speed, precision, distance, procedures, or techniques in execution. This goes to say that with regards to the academic performance of secondary school students, parents are imperative for efficient functioning of the psychomotor skills,

however parental separation pose a serious threat to the development of the psychomotor skills of secondary school students. There is therefore need to explore the extent to which parental separation influence academic performance of students in secondary schools in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State as the gap created by this is long overdue especially in the context of secondary school Education.

Secondary Education is one aspect of educational institutions in Nigeria that is designed specifically to train and prepare students for middle-level services in both manufacturing and service industries. One of the objectives of secondary Education according to Atuyi (2019), is the acquisition of both physical and intellectual skills which will enable individuals to be self-reliant and useful members of the society. It must be emphasized that secondary Education in Nigeria is for six years duration, Upper Basic (3 years) and Senior Secondary School (3 years). The two stages are both vocational and academic in nature. The broad goal of secondary education as stated in the National Policy on Education is to prepare the individual citizen for useful living within the society and preparation for higher education (FRN, 2013).

Secondary Education does not only occupy an important place in the Nigeria Education System but also serves as a link between the primary and tertiary levels of education; and because of its central position, its programmes have functional roles such as giving students access to higher education as well as preparing them for work. According to Ibe (2016), secondary Education provides avenue for

interaction among human being with divergent needs, interest and motives. Enose (2020), summed it up by noting that educational organization such as secondary school system exists in a symbolic relationship with the environment while utilizing both human and material resources for the production of educated, socialized graduates. Onuoma (2023) posited that the both the private and public secondary schools play significant role in the growth and development of the educational system. However, the focus of this study is on the public secondary schools. Public secondary schools are government-funded and managed educational institutions, typically providing free or low-cost education to students within specific regions. According to Onuoma (2023) the public secondary schools are operated by local or state authorities to provide secondary education. These schools are accessible to the public, differing from private, fee-paying institutions. It is generally open to all residents within a specific geographic, municipal, or school district boundary (Dike, 2023). Obunko (2022) noted that public secondary schools in Enugu Education Zone are thirty one in number, and are critical, though they face challenges with partnerships, impacting performance, however, must follow state-mandated curriculum standards, which may include specialized vocational or technical programs. The public secondary schools are essential for ensuring universal access to education, often serving a diverse student population (Ossai, 2023).

It is worthy to note that, the secondary school level is predominantly

made of students who are in their adolescent stages and are constantly at conflict with the developmental changes they undergo which gives them the disposition of the behaviour they exhibit. Thus, parents are considered as the primary shapers of their children behaviour. They have the power, ability to shape, sustain and develop their children who will be interested, creative and tolerant, thorough and positively involved in the learning process and educational activities. On the other hand parents who do not involve in their children educational process maybe as a result of separation are also considered to be capable of repressing and destroying the motivation and ability of their children. Ogbu (2018), posited that a child's behaviour in school depends on how successfully the child was managed by his parents in the home environment. In line with the above, Ncheta (2023), posited that the manner by which parents raise their children determines level of discipline, expectations, domains, attentiveness and academic performance in school irrespective of gender.

Gender is a socially learned behaviour and expectation associated with male and female. It is described as the biological sex of individuals in terms of being male or female. In Nigerian society, there are differences and inequalities between women and men in responsibilities assigned, activities taken, access to and control over resources as well as possession of leadership qualities (Abayi, 2022). Male and female significantly differ in their cognitive abilities (Ugwu, 2021). Ede (2018), noted that male students develop better psychomotor skills more than their

female counterparts. Aleke (2016), noted that male and female students do not differ significantly in their ability to cooperate with others in work places. Alhourani (2023), argued that gender does not influence students' academic performance in secondary schools. This researcher is of a thought that if adequate attention is not paid to the influence of parental separation on the academic performance of students in secondary school in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State, education delivery might be jeopardized. It is worthy to note that despite the fact that the fundamental objective of a secondary school is to facilitate the total and fullest development of each student, in terms of enriching his or her cognitive, affective and psychomotor skills, parental separation seems to pose serious challenge to this goal, unfortunately, existing literatures are silent on the influence of parental separation on the academic performance of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State. It is against this background that the researcher is motivated to ascertain the influence of parental separation on the academic performance of students in secondary school in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State. This constituted the gap this study filled.

Statement of the Problem

The rate of parental separation from observation seems to be on the increase. This separation often occurs in different ways which include; separation due to death of a parent, marital divorce, job relocation as well as separation due to polygamy effects. Yet with this observable high rate of parental separation, little or nothing has been done to control the seeming influence

of parental separation on academic performance of students in secondary schools with particular reference to Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State. It is proven that Nigeria's divorce rate reached 2.9 per cent in 2023 based on available data on marriage and divorce, which translates to 1.8 per cent divorces per 1,000 people in the same year and consequently, Nigeria was ranked eleventh among the countries with the highest parental separation rate is a factor of serious concern. The exposition that Nigeria was on the list of countries with high parental separation rates as revealed by the United States website, is a source of worry in this study, as the fate of secondary school students and their academic performance particularly in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State is yet to be ascertained. Unfortunately, no empirical evidence known to the researcher provided a concrete data on the influence of parental separation on the academic performance of male and female students in secondary schools particularly in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State. Thus, the problem of this study put in question form is; 'to what extent does parental separation influence academic performance of students in secondary schools Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State.'

Purpose of the Study

The main purpose of this study was to determine the influence of parental separation on the academic performance of students in secondary schools in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State. Specifically, this study sought to;

1. ascertain the extent to which parental separation influence the cognitive

skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State.

2. find out the extent to which parental separation influence the affective skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State.
3. determine the extent to which parental separation influence the Psychomotor skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State.

Research Questions

The following research questions guided the study:

1. To what extent does parental separation influence the cognitive skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State?
2. To what extent does parental separation influence the affective skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State?
3. To what extent does parental separation influence the psychomotor skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State?

Hypotheses

The following null hypotheses were tested at .05 level of significance

HO₁: There is no significant difference in the mean scores of male and female students on the extent to which parental separation influence the cognitive skills of secondary school

students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State.

HO₂: There is no significant difference in the mean scores of male and female students on the extent to which parental separation influence the affective skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State.

HO₃: There is no significant difference in the mean scores of male and female students on the extent to which parental separation influence the psychomotor skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State.

Method

Descriptive survey research design was utilized for this study. Descriptive survey research design, according to Nworgu (2015), is one in which a group of people or items are studied by collecting and analyzing data from only a few people or items considered to be representative of the entire group. A descriptive survey research is concerned with specified population of persons, items or situations, in a defined geographical location. It involves the collection of relevant data for or about the population that enables the description of the person, items or situations the way they are (Ndubuisi, 2021). The descriptive survey research design was considered suitable for the study as it solicited for information from the respondents directly and afforded all the respondents equal chance of being chosen for the study. The population for the study comprised all the 28,310 secondary school students in the 31 public secondary schools in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State.

The population was made up of 10, 491 male and 17,819 female students in all the public secondary schools in zone. The sample size for this study was 565 public secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State. The sample was made up of 209 male and 356 female secondary school students in the zone. The researcher used proportionate stratified random sampling technique to draw 2% of male and female secondary school students from the 31 public secondary schools in the zone. First, the researcher got the total population of 10, 491 male and 17,819 female students from the data collected from the PPSMB. From this the researcher drew 2% of male (209) and female (356) secondary school students, from each stratum respectively. The derived sample size was summed up to get the sample size of 565. This was in line with Uzoagulu (2012), who stated that when the respondents' population are in thousands 5% or below of the entire population can serve as the sample. A self-structured questionnaire named "Parental Separation and Academic Performance of Secondary School Students' Questionnaire (PSAPSSSQ), developed by the researcher was used for data collection. The instrument has two sections; A and B. Section A contains the respondents' bio- data while section B is divided into three clusters with 37 items, structured to assist the researcher in providing answers to the research questions that were formulated to guide the study. Cluster 1 is on cognitive skills with 12 items, Cluster 2 is on affective skills with 12 items while cluster 3 is on psychomotor skills with 13 items. The instrument was on

a 4-point scale with response options of Very Great Extent (VGE), Great Extent (GE), Little Extent (LE) and Very Little Extent (VLE).

In order to ensure the validity of the instrument, three draft copies of the instrument together with the research topic, purpose of the study, research questions, hypotheses, and the developed instrument were given to three experts in the Faculty of Education. Two experts from the Department of Educational Management, while the other expert from the Measurement and Evaluation Unit; Department of Mathematics and Computer Education, Enugu State University of Science and Technology, Enugu. The experts were requested to assess the relevance, adequacy, suitability and comprehensiveness of the items in addressing the research questions as well as the clarity of the instruction to the respondents. The initial 26 generated items were increased to 37 items as suggested by the validators, while double barrel questions and grammatical errors were corrected as well. The reliability of the instrument was determined by administering 30 copies of the questionnaire to a sample of 12 male and 18 female secondary school students from public secondary schools in Agbani Education Zone of Enugu State in a trial test to ascertain the internal consistency of the instrument. The choice of secondary school students in Agbani Education Zone public secondary schools was informed by the fact that both zones have the same educational characteristics in terms of administration, population and environment. Thus, it served perfectly well as a similar population for the

study. The respondents were assured of confidentiality of all the information they supplied. Data collected from the respondents' responses were analyzed using Cronbach Alpha reliability estimate. Cronbach Alpha was used because the instrument was administered once to the respondents and it was poly-dichotomously scored. The instrument has three clusters, each section yielded the following reliability coefficient; cluster 1 had .71, cluster 2 had .79, and cluster 3 had .70. The overall reliability coefficient stood at .73, indicating that the instrument is reliable and suitable for the study. The instrument was administered to the 565 respondents using direct delivery and retrieval method. The distribution of the questionnaire to the sampled respondents was done personally by the researcher with the help of three research assistants who were briefed by the researcher in a one-day consultative meeting on the modalities for administering and retrieving the instrument to the respondents. The use of research assistants who were teachers, were chosen in order to facilitate the distribution and retrieval of the completed copies of questionnaire. Out of

Results

Research Question 1: To what extent does parental separation influence the cognitive skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State?

Table 1: Mean and Standard Deviation on the Extent to which Parental Separation Influence the Cognitive Skills of Secondary School Students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State

S/N	Influence of parental separation on the students' cognitive skills include;	Male Students (205)			Female Students (257)			Overall (462)		
		Mean	SD	Dec	Mean	SD	Dec	Mean	SD	Dec
1	distracting students mental skills	1.68	0.95	LE	1.82	0.91	LE	1.76	0.93	LE
2	inability of students to pick out the important points from materials read	1.28	0.66	LE	1.77	0.96	LE	1.55	0.87	LE
3	inability of students to comprehend information in the materials read	1.40	0.72	LE	1.85	0.91	LE	1.65	0.86	LE
4	poorer educational outcomes	1.31	0.73	LE	1.78	1.09	LE	1.57	0.98	LE

the 565 copies of the administered instrument only 462 copies were correctly filled and returned, while 103 copies were not returned. Mean and standard deviation were employed in answering the research questions that are raised to guide the study, while t-test statistic at .05 level of significance was used to test the null hypotheses formulated to guide the study. For the decision rule, real limits of the numbers were applied for the research questions. Thus, the upper and lower limits of the mean were used to interpret the respondents mean scores as follows:

Very Great Extent (VGE) —3.50 — 4.00

Great Extent (GE) —2.50 — 3.49

Little Extent (LE) —1.50 — 2.49

Very Little Extent (VLE) —1.00 — 1.49

For the hypotheses, the bench mark was that if the value of the calculated-t is equal to or greater than the critical t-value at .05 level of significance, the null hypothesis was rejected. On the other hand, if the calculated t-value is less than the critical t-value at .05, level of confidence the hypothesis was not be rejected.

5	students often get lost in the details of the materials read	1.48	0.70	LE	1.89	0.91	LE	1.71	0.85	LE
6	inability of students to memorize concepts taught	1.74	0.83	LE	2.11	0.95	LE	1.95	0.91	LE
7	inability of students to develop problem solving skills	1.98	0.88	LE	2.40	0.93	LE	2.21	0.93	LE
8	inability of students to recall concepts taught	1.57	0.79	LE	2.12	1.00	LE	1.87	0.95	LE
9	inability of students to develop ability to discuss lesson learnt from materials studied	1.43	0.69	LE	1.79	0.87	LE	1.63	0.81	LE
10	inability of students to illustrate a given concept correctly	1.53	0.73	LE	1.84	0.80	LE	1.70	0.79	LE
11	inability of students to formulate new ideas	1.28	0.60	LE	1.47	0.71	LE	1.39	0.67	LE
12	lower educational achievements	1.40	0.84	LE	1.89	1.10	LE	1.68	1.02	LE
WEIGHTED AVERAGE		1.51	.76	LE	1.89	.93	LE	1.72	.88	LE

Table 1 shows the results obtained from the secondary school students on the extent to which parental separation influence the cognitive skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State. The Table shows that male students had mean scores indicating little extent on extent with their response indices ranging from 1.98 to 1.28, with weighted average of 1.51. The female secondary school students had mean scores that ranged from 1.47 to 2.40; with weighted average of 1.89. Overall, the mean scores of the respondents ranged from 1.39 to 2.21, with a cluster mean of 1.72 and a standard deviation of .88. The results showed that to a little extent parental separation influenced the cognitive skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State.

HO₁: There is no significant difference in the mean scores of male and female students on the extent to which parental separation influence the cognitive skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State.

Table 2: Mean, SD and t-test Analysis of the Male and Female Students on the Extent to which Parental Separation Influence the Cognitive Skills of Secondary School Students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State.

Gender	N	Mean	SD	df	t-value	Sig. (2tailed)	Decision
Female	257	1.89	.93	460	8.546	.000	RejectH ₀₁
Male	205	1.51	.76				

Table 2 shows that there is no significant difference in the mean scores of male and female students on the extent to which parental separation influence the cognitive skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State. With mean and standard deviation of female secondary school students (N = 1.89, SD = .93 and their male counterpart as (N = 1.51, SD = .76), $t(460) = 8.456$, $P = .000$ ($P < 0.05$). Therefore, the null hypothesis was rejected. Thus, there is significant difference between the mean scores of male and female students on the extent to which parental separation influence the cognitive skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State.

Research Question 2: To what extent does parental separation influence the affective skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State?

Table 3: Mean and Standard Deviation on the Extent to which Parental Separation Influence the Affective Skills of Secondary School Students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State

S/N	Influence of parental separation on the students' affective skills include inability to;	Male Students (205)	Female Students (257)	Overall (462)
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		Mean	SD	Dec	Mean	SD	Dec	Mean	SD	Dec
13	appreciate the act of consistent study	2.98	0.87	GE	2.81	0.89	GE	2.89	0.88	GE
14	making recitation	3.29	0.72	GE	3.32	0.67	GE	3.31	0.69	GE
15	organize study materials	2.79	0.89	GE	2.80	0.88	GE	2.79	0.89	GE
16	making reports	3.25	0.67	GE	3.36	0.61	GE	3.31	0.64	GE
17	make description of concepts	3.00	0.97	GE	2.90	1.00	GE	2.95	0.98	GE
18	make explanation of ideas	2.76	1.02	GE	2.51	1.10	GE	2.62	1.07	GE
19	make differentiation of similar issues	3.32	0.47	GE	3.31	0.46	GE	3.31	0.46	GE
20	present questions	3.30	0.71	GE	3.18	0.81	GE	3.23	0.77	GE
21	make integration of knowledge	3.30	0.60	GE	3.23	0.74	GE	3.26	0.68	GE
22	modify ideas	3.02	0.88	GE	3.16	0.89	GE	3.10	0.89	GE
23	make justification of ideas	2.76	0.91	GE	2.95	0.83	GE	2.87	0.87	GE
24	control emotional stress	2.99	0.66	GE	3.04	0.66	GE	3.01	0.66	GE
WEIGHTED AVERAGE		3.06	.78	GE	3.05	.80	GE	3.05	.79	GE

Table 3 shows the results obtained from the secondary school students on the extent to which parental separation influence the affective skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State. The Table shows that male students had mean scores indicating great extent; their response indices ranging from 2.76 to 3.32, with weighted average of 3.06. The female secondary school students had mean scores that ranged from 2.51 to 3.36; with weighted average of 3.05. Overall, the mean scores of the respondents ranged from 2.62 to 3.31, with a cluster mean of 3.05 and a standard deviation of .79. The results show that to a great extent parental separation influence the affective skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State.

HO₂: There is no significant difference in the mean scores of male and female students on the extent to which parental separation influence the affective skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State.

Table 6: Mean, SD and t-test Analysis of the Male and Female Retired Teachers on the Extent to which Physical Frailty Constitute Challenge to the Retired Teachers of Secondary Schools in Enugu State

Gender	N	Mean	SD	df	t-value	Sig. (2tailed)	Decision
Female	257	3.05	.80	460	-.555	.579	Do Not Reject H ₀₂
Male	205	3.06	.78				

Table 4 shows that there is no significant difference in the mean scores of male and female students on the extent to which parental separation influence the affective skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State. With mean and standard deviation of female secondary school students (N = 3.05, SD = .80 and their male counterpart as (N = 3.06, SD = .78), $t(460) = -.555$, $P = .579$ ($P > 0.05$). Therefore, the null hypothesis was not rejected. Thus, there is no significant difference between the mean scores of male and female students on the extent to which parental separation influence the affective skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State.

Research Question 3: To what extent does parental separation influence the psychomotor skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State?

Table 5: Mean and Standard Deviation on the Extent to which Parental Separation Influence the Psychomotor Skills of Secondary School Students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State

S/N	Influence of parental separation on the students' psychomotor skills include;	Male Teachers (205)			Female Teacher (257)			Overall (462)		
		Mean	SD	Dec	Mean	SD	Dec	Mean	SD	Dec
25	inability of students to be assertive.	1.61	0.85	LE	1.65	0.84	LE	1.63	0.84	LE
26	inability to assist students in improvisation	1.45	0.80	VLE	1.81	0.95	LE	1.65	0.90	LE
27	inability of students to display adaptive behaviour towards learning	1.54	0.83	LE	1.78	0.93	LE	1.67	0.89	LE
28	inability of students to demonstrate knowledge of concepts taught	1.38	0.78	VLE	1.57	0.91	LE	1.49	0.86	VLE
29	inability of students to perform action with written instruction	1.58	0.73	LE	1.82	0.81	LE	1.72	0.78	LE
30	inability of students to replicate actions after a visual demonstration	1.80	0.83	LE	1.93	0.88	LE	1.87	0.86	LE
31	inability of students to perform action with verbal instruction	2.12	0.88	LE	2.32	0.89	LE	2.23	0.89	LE
32	lower progression in psychomotor skills	1.74	0.83	LE	2.06	0.90	LE	1.92	0.88	LE
33	lower progression in graphical abilities	1.52	0.72	LE	1.70	0.85	LE	1.62	0.80	LE
34	inability of students to make oral presentation	1.97	1.17	LE	2.55	1.30	GE	2.29	1.27	LE
35	inability of students' to make public speech in class	1.67	1.07	LE	2.22	1.30	LE	1.97	1.24	LE
36	inability of students to discuss issues with peers	1.84	1.05	LE	2.48	1.07	LE	2.20	1.11	LE
37	inability of students to involve in team work in class	2.15	1.28	LE	2.53	1.14	GE	2.36	1.22	LE
WEIGHTED AVERAGE		1.72	.91	LE	2.03	.98	LE	1.89	.96	LE

Table 5 shows the results obtained from the secondary school students' on the extent to which parental separation influence the psychomotor skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State. The table shows that male secondary school students had mean scores indicating little extent; their response indices ranging from 1.38 to 2.15, with weighted average of 1.72. The female secondary school students had mean scores that ranged from 1.57 to 2.55; with weighted average of 2.03. In overall, the mean scores of the respondents ranged from 1.49 to 2.36, with a cluster mean of 1.89 and a standard deviation of .96. The results show that to a little extent parental separation influenced the psychomotor skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State.

HO₃: There is no significant difference in the mean scores of male and female students on the extent to which parental separation influence the psychomotor skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State.

Table 6: Mean, SD and t-test analysis of the Male and Female Students on the Extent to which Parental Separation Influence the Psychomotor Skills of Secondary School Students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State.

Gender	N	Mean	SD	df	t-value	Sig. (2tailed)	Decision
Female	257	2.03	.98	460	6.409	.000	Reject H ₀₂
Male	205	1.72	.91				

Table 6 shows that there is no significant difference in the mean scores of male and female students on the extent to which parental separation influence the psychomotor skills of secondary

school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State. With mean and standard deviation of female secondary school students ($N = 2.03$, $SD = .98$ and their male counterpart as ($N = 1.72$, $SD = .91$), $t(460) = 6.409$, $P = .000$ ($P < 0.05$). Therefore, the null hypothesis was rejected. Thus, there is significant difference between the mean scores of male and female students on the extent to which parental separation influence the psychomotor skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State.

Discussion of Findings

The findings of this study were discussed in line with the research questions that guided the study and hypotheses tested.

Extent Parental Separation Influenced the Cognitive Skills of Secondary School Students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State.

The finding revealed that to a little extent parental separation influenced the cognitive skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State. Similarly, there is significant difference between the mean scores of male and female students on the extent to which parental separation influence the cognitive skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State. The finding contradicts Gruber (2024) who posited that parental separation is associated with deteriorating material and subjective wellbeing in the short term, resulting in average lower wellbeing later in life and occurs in different forms such as; separation due to death of a parent; marital divorce; job relocation as well as separation due to polygamy effects. The finding is not in line with Uduak (2017) who noted that parental separation has a long and lasting impact on lives of any student. The is not in consonance with Sigal (2022) who averred that it is known that parental separation is associated with multiple problems for

students as youths that extend into adulthood, including internalizing and externalizing problems, interpersonal difficulties, poor physical health, and substance abuse. Considering that children learn and grow through three overlapping spheres of influence: family, school and community. These three spheres must form partnerships to best meet the needs of the child. Thus, there is need to create awareness on the danger of parental separation on secondary school students' academic performance in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State.

Extent Parental Separation Influence the Affective Skills of Secondary School Students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State.

The finding showed that to a great extent parental separation influence the affective skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State. Similarly, there is no significant difference between the mean scores of male and female students on the extent to which parental separation influence the affective skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State. This finding is in line with Uduak (2017) who noted that parental separation has a long and lasting impact on lives of any student. The finding aligns with the research report by Ogenyi (2019) which revealed that separated parents have been found as a crucial factor

causing anti-social problems and poor academic performances among secondary school students. The finding agrees with Okoroafor (2017) who stated that parental separation not only affects the behavioural adjustment and potential of students but lead to drop-out from school as a result of difficult emotional experiences and trauma. Being that parents are considered as the primary shapers of their children behaviour. They have the power, ability to shape, sustain and develop their children who will be interested, creative and tolerant, thorough and positively involved in the learning process and educational activities. Efforts should be made to educate the parents on the dangers of parental separation on students' academic performance in secondary school in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State.

Extent Parental Separation Influenced the Psychomotor Skills of Secondary School Students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State

The finding of the study indicated that to a little extent parental separation influenced the psychomotor skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State. Similarly, there is significant difference between the mean scores of male and female students on the extent to which parental separation influence the psychomotor skills of secondary school students in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State. The finding contradicts Sigal (2022) who averred that it is known that parental separation is associated with multiple problems for students as youths that extend into adulthood, including internalizing and externalizing problems, interpersonal difficulties, poor physical health, and

substance abuse. The finding is not in line with Uduak (2017) who noted that parental separation has a long and lasting impact on lives of any student. The is not in consonance with Gruber (2024) who posited that parental separation is associated with deteriorating material and subjective wellbeing in the short term, resulting in average lower wellbeing later in life and occurs in different forms such as; separation due to death of a parent; marital divorce; job relocation as well as separation due to polygamy effects. With the fact that the home should be an environment where the child learns the skills, attitudes and behaviour which could mold them into a productive and well behaved individual. There is need for periodic seminar for parents across all secondary schools in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State to enlighten the parents on the need for good home environment and enhancement of students' academic performance.

Educational Implication of the Findings

The implications of this study are that;

The study holds implication for the government, as through the finding of this study the government will proffer solutions to cases of parental separation affecting secondary school students and strengthen her policy as it affects separation in Enugu State, which seem to be ignored over the years. The study holds implication for school authorities, as through the result of this study they shall be equipped with the need for special care and attention on students from separated homes in secondary

schools. The study shall form a guide to the school authorities on the best strategy to be adopted in the school environment at each given situation while dealing with students from separated homes in secondary schools. If the academic performance of secondary school students continues to decline as a result of parental separation, the secondary education will be jeopardized and teachers in active service would be discouraged. This will cause a general decline in the performance of the teachers and students.

The study holds serious implication for guidance counsellors whom are saddled with the responsibility of resolving both individuals', family and social maladjustment issues. The study shall form a guide which they shall base their strategies in students from separated parents at all levels of education especially in secondary schools in Enugu Education Zone, and as well educate the parents on the right and most suitable parenting style. The guidance counsellors are better equipped through this study with necessary data and knowledge needed in assisting parents out of parental challenges that instigate separation. The adoptions of these practices are basically the gap that this study filled.

Recommendations

Based on the findings of the study the following recommendations were made.

- There is need to create awareness on the danger of parental separation on secondary school students' academic performance in Enugu Education Zone of Enugu State.
- There is need for periodic seminar for parents across all secondary schools in Enugu Education Zone of

Enugu State to enlighten the parents on the need for good home environment and enhancement of students' academic performance.

- Special care should be taken by teachers and school authorities on students who are victims of parental separation in classroom.
- Deliberate efforts should be made by the Ministry of Gender Affairs in Enugu State at motivating and strengthening couples to seek counselling help at the face of crises. This ministry has a role to play in reducing the increasing rate of parental separation.

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